ashes to the winds while crying, ‘Away with the learning of the clerks, away with it!’ Thomas Walsingham, a monk in St Albans Abbey who witnessed the destruction of the abbey’s archive first hand, described how the rebels ‘set fire to all court rolls and muniments, so that after they had got rid of these records of their ancient service their lords would not be able to claim any right at all against them at some future time’.[48] Killing the documents erased the debts.

Similar attacks on archives characterised numerous other insurgencies throughout history. For example, during the Great Jewish Revolt in 66 CE, one of the first things the rebels did upon capturing Jerusalem was to set fire to the central archive in order to destroy records of debts, thereby wining the support of the populace.[49] During the French Revolution in 1789, numerous local and regional archives were destroyed for comparable reasons.[50] Many rebels might have been illiterate, but they knew that without the documents the bureaucratic machine couldn’t function.

I can sympathise with the suspicion of government bureaucracies and of the power of official documents, because they have played an important role in my own family. My maternal grandfather had his life upended by a government census and by the inability to find a crucial document. My grandfather Bruno Luttinger was born in 1913 in Chernivtsi. Today this town is in Ukraine, but in 1913 it was part of the Habsburg Empire. Bruno’s father disappeared in the First World War and he was raised by his mother, Chaya-Pearl. When the war was over, Chernivtsi was annexed to Romania. In the late 1930s, as Romania became a fascist dictatorship, an important plank of its new antisemitic policy was to conduct a Jewish census.

In 1936 official statistics said that 758,000 Jews lived in Romania, constituting 4.2 per cent of the population. The same official statistics said that the total number of refugees from the USSR, Jews and non-Jews, was about 11,000. In 1937 a new fascist government came to power, headed by Prime Minister Octavian Goga. Goga was a renowned poet as well as a politician, but he quickly graduated from patriotic poetry to fake statistics and oppressive bureaucracy. He and his colleagues ignored the official statistics and claimed that hundreds of thousands of Jewish refugees were flooding into Romania. In several interviews Goga claimed that half a million Jews had entered Romania illegally and that the total number of Jews in the country was 1.5 million. Government organs, far-right statisticians and popular newspapers regularly cited even higher figures.